

New perspectives to improve fairness and equity in PGR assessment criteria

Equity, Diversity and Inclusion in Postgraduate Research

Friday 3 November 2023, 11.15-12.15

**Dr Paulina Rodriguez Anaiz, Margaret James, Danielle Watkis, University of Oxford,
Tanne Heathershaw, University of Cambridge**

Lauren Russell, Nottingham Trent University

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What is the purpose of a PhD?

Selecting for equity in doctoral admissions

Bukola Oyinloye
Kathryn Arnold

UKCGE Conference on EDI in PG Research
Friday, November 03, 2023



Yorkshire Consortium for
Equity in Doctoral Education

What is YCEDE?

A collaboration between five universities in Yorkshire, 12 UKRI funded Doctoral Training partnerships and Centres for Doctoral Training plus a number of external partners dedicated to equity at doctoral level.

Central to YCEDE is the question of access to doctoral study for graduates from Black, Asian and Minority Ethnic backgrounds.

Funded by OfS, Research England plus partners



YCEDE objectives

1. Widen opportunities to ensure equity of access to and participation in research.
2. Change institutional practices and culture to reduce inequality in offer rates.
3. Ensure experience for PGRs of Colour by developing institutions in which they feel a valued part of the wider scholarly community.
4. Provide evidence base for interventions to share widely across the HE sector and beyond.

YCEDE WS2: PGR recruitment and selection for E&D

1. Document selection processes and practices, including criteria employed and the role of individual selectors
2. Identify any outlier programmes which exhibit already very positive offer and enrolment rates for underrepresented minoritised ethnic applicants
3. Analyse successful and unsuccessful applications by students from different ethnicities to identify any salient features
4. Cascade results and reforms across the consortium and beyond, including the creation of a training workshop programme for staff at partner institutions and DTPs/CDTs

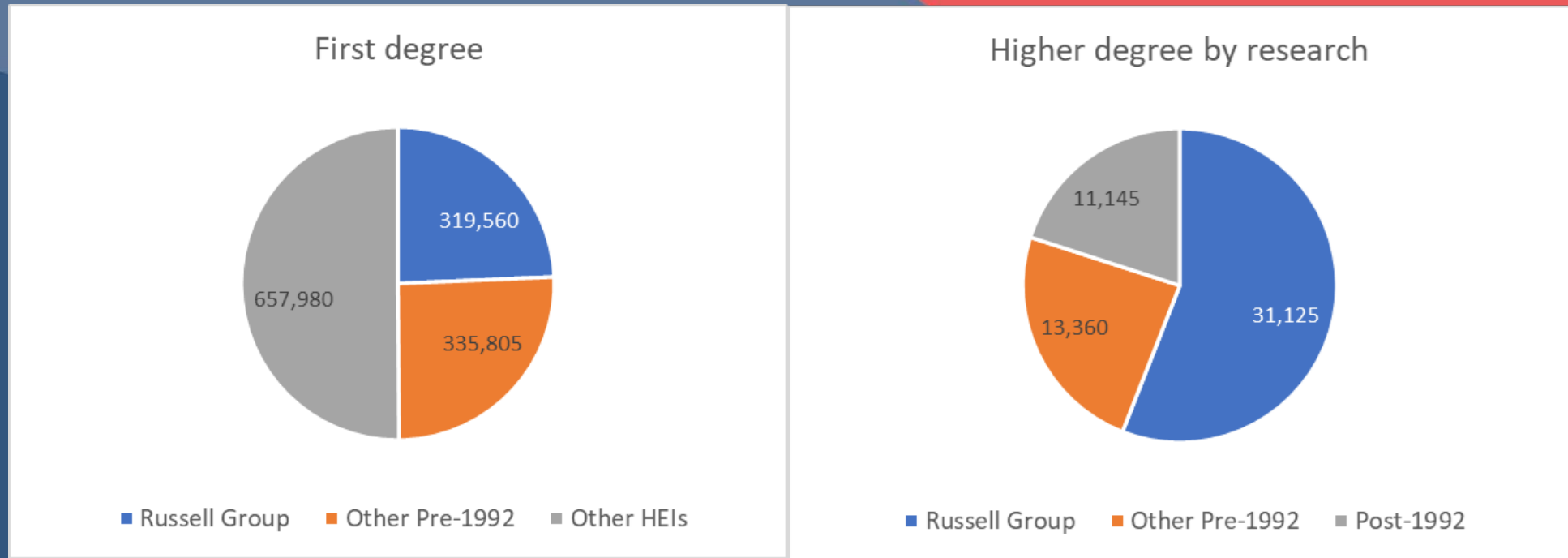
Anglo-American partnership



C-CIDE 
California Consortium for Inclusive Doctoral Education

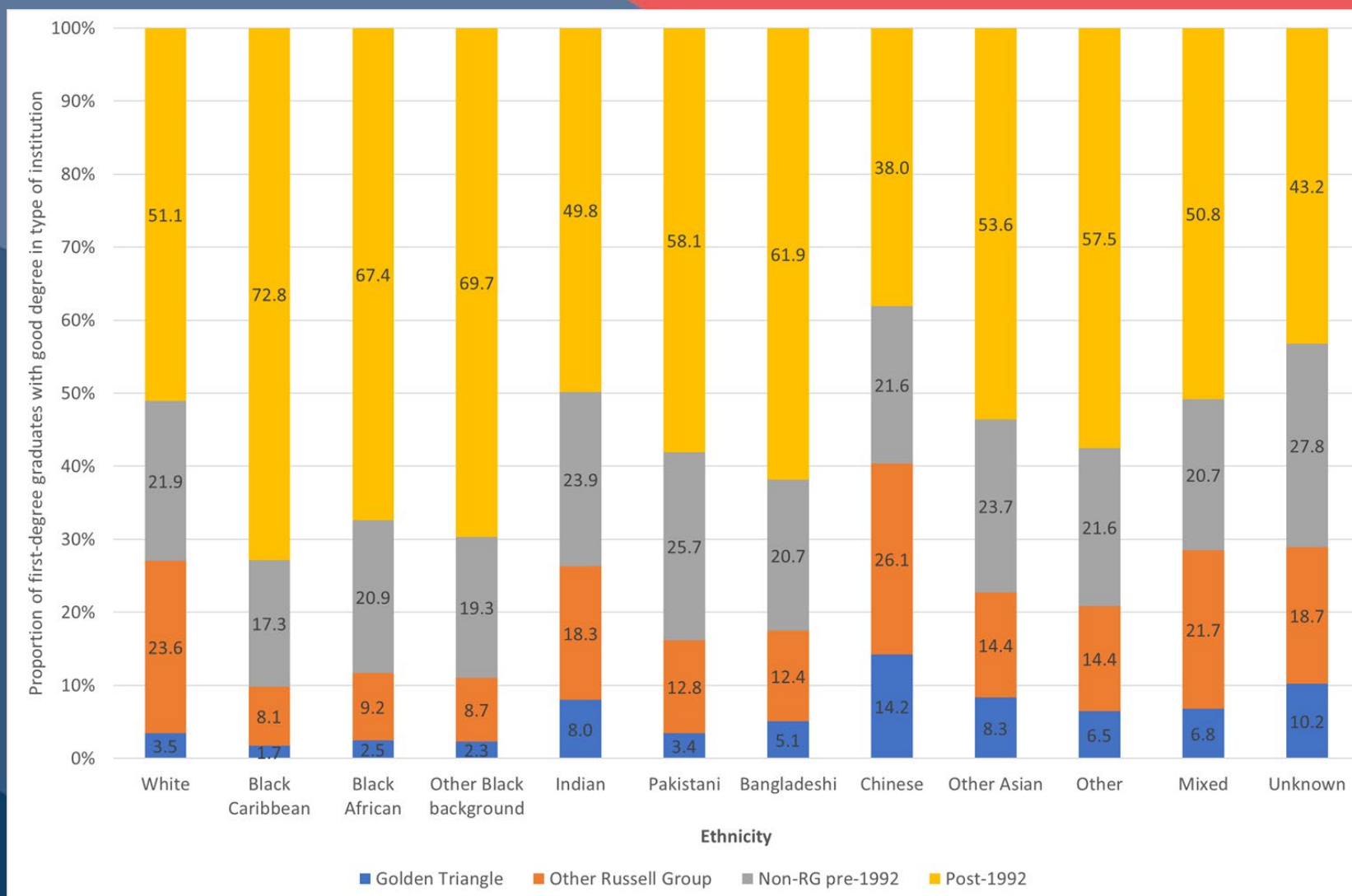


Some existing data: Institutional selectivity



Institutional location of students (UK-domiciled only) by level, 2018/19

Some existing data: Institutional distributions



Mission group location of first-degree graduates from selected ethnicities, 2012/13 – 2016/17 (UK-domiciled graduates with 'good' degree only)

Key points from existing data on PhD admissions

- UK graduates from minoritised backgrounds underrepresented in PGR
- There is a PhD 'offer gap'
- Doing the same thing will lead to the same outcome

Study of selectors' perspectives of PhD candidates

- Mixed methods study with multiple objectives
 - Interviews to explore criteria specifically around participants' conceptions of ideal and successful students (Sciences, A&H, SS)
- Findings – themes
 - Beyond technical competence
 - Cognitive 'technical skills' important, but overwhelming valuing of 'not just technically competence' but of diverse personal attributes and motivation
 - 'You miss 'em when they're gone'
 - Valuing of participation in research communities within and outside institution; acknowledgement of influence of students' personal life contexts.
 - Ideal attributes typically discussed in relation to students' experiences, success attributes in relation to thesis completion

Implications

- Integrating equity into selection consistent with supervisors' most valued attributes, i.e., attributes which pose considerably less equity challenges than those presently explicitly selected for
 - Non-cognitive characteristics do not typically feature explicitly in processes but are said to feature implicitly in practices
- Need to foster and support environments in which more holistic selection processes (Kent & McCarthy, 2016) feature more prominently

Mapping existing initiatives – DTPs/CDTs

- Promising initiatives at the [pre]application, shortlisting, interviewing and offer stages, as well as ring fenced funding
- Changes attributed to
 - equity/diversity mindset
 - committed people and leadership
 - openness to change, and the iterative process / challenging conversations it may entail
- Challenges
 - data and system consistency
 - legality – positive action, not positive discrimination
 - limits to anonymity, e.g., applicant compliance; recognition through research centre names, etc.

The background features a series of overlapping, curved shapes in shades of blue and red. On the left, there are three concentric-like curved segments in dark blue, medium blue, and light blue. On the right, there are similar curved segments in light red, medium red, and dark red. The text 'Thank You' is centered in the middle of the image, overlapping the blue and red areas.

Thank You

References

- Kent, J. D., & McCarthy, M. T. (2016). *Holistic review in graduate admissions*. Council of Graduate Schools. https://cgsnet.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/01/CGS_HolisticReview_final_web.pdf
- Williams, P., Bath, S., Arday, J., & Lewis, C. (2019). *The broken pipeline: Barriers to Black PhD students accessing Research Council funding*. Leading Routes.

Close the Gap

Fair Admissions in Postgraduate Research

**UKCGE Workshop: New perspectives to improve
fairness and equity in PGR assessment criteria**

Margaret James, University of Oxford

Tanne Heathershaw, University of Cambridge

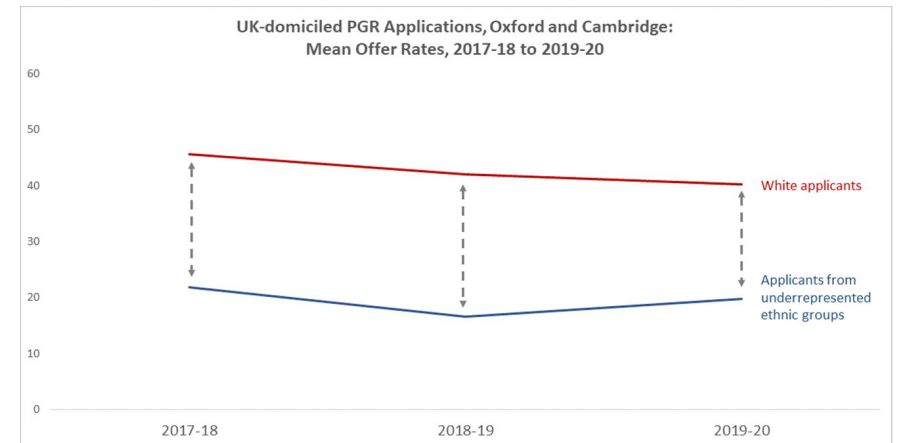


Close the Gap aims to transform doctoral student selection at Oxford and Cambridge to develop a socially and epistemically just and inclusive environment for world-leading research

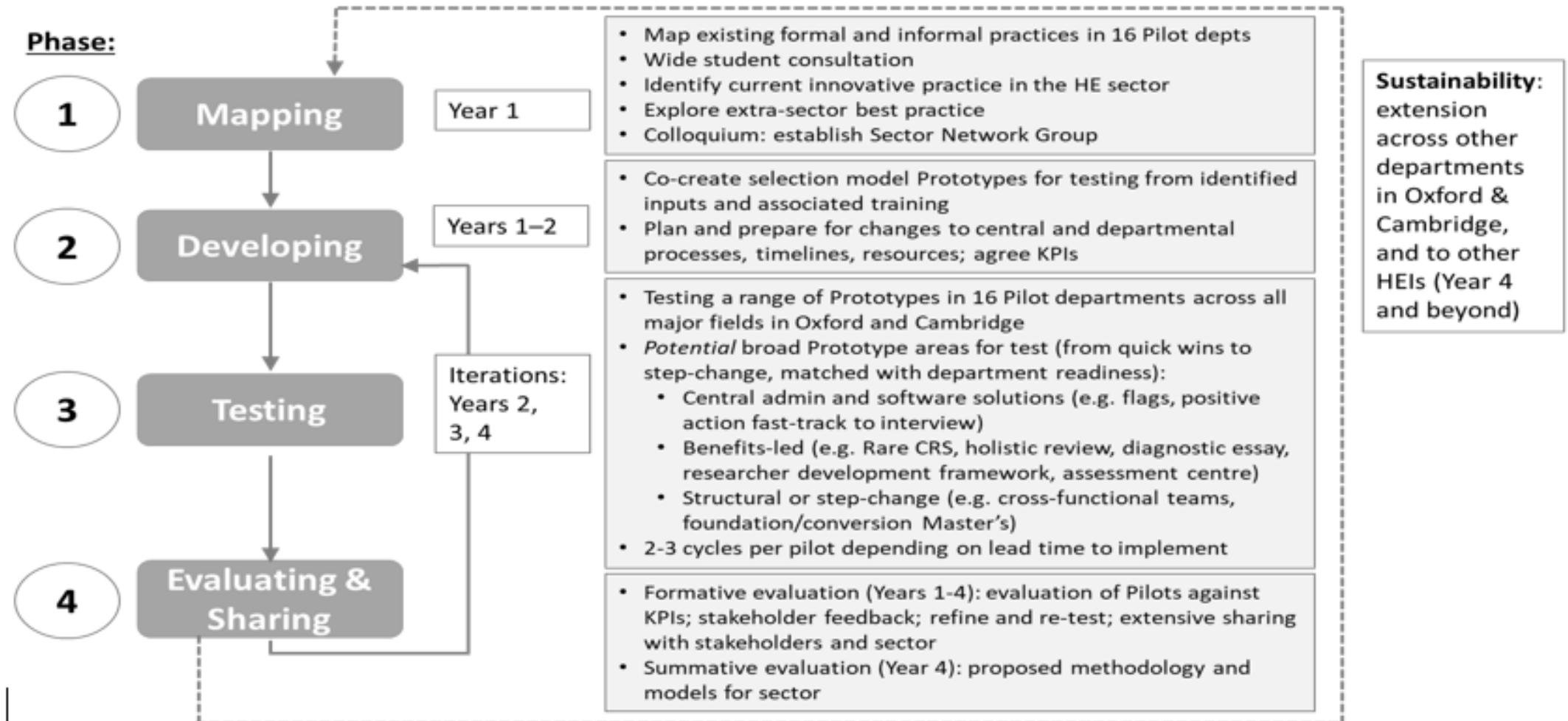
Oxford and Cambridge are analysing formal and informal graduate admissions cultures, systems and practices, and developing and testing new disciplinary-specific, race-literate, fair selection processes that are designed to bring about meaningful change in doctoral candidate election systems. We are working with our partners: Blueprint for All, The Careers Research and Advisory Centre (CRAC) Ltd., Leading Routes, and Rare.

Offer Gap: Applicants from Black British, British Bangladeshi and British Pakistani backgrounds have historically been around half as likely to receive offers to study as their white counterparts.

Close the Gap aims to understand the formal and informal processes and practices underlying postgraduate admissions, with the goal of reducing and closing this gap.



Project Method ‘Map and Test’



What have we learned?

Doctoral admissions are a complex process

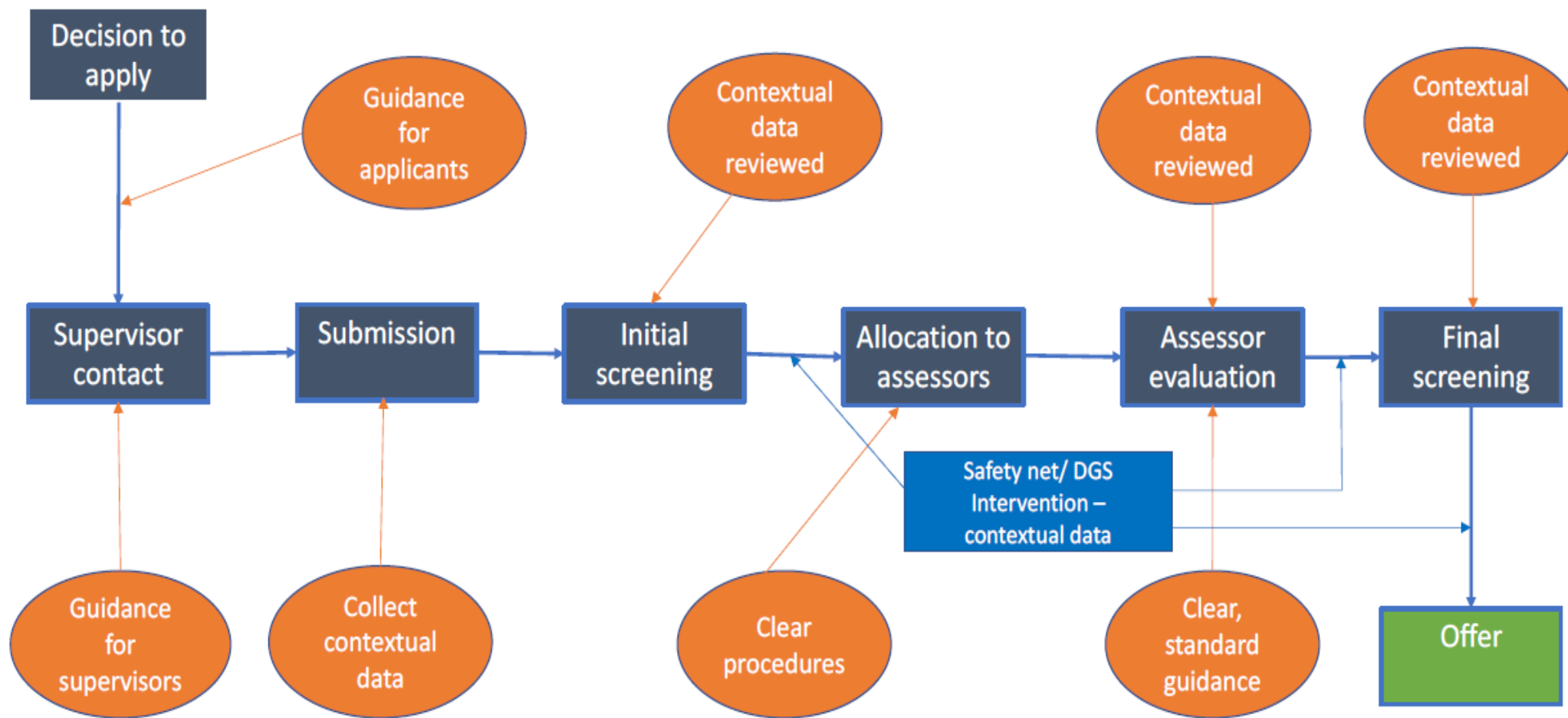
- Different understandings of the purposes and outcomes of doctoral education may lead to different admissions criteria being used or weighted differently.
- There are tensions in the admissions criteria (such as between merit and diversity).

Offer rate gap has no single root cause

- Bias can enter and become entrenched in admissions systems and dynamics, which may work against the desire for greater diversity and equity.

To reshape the system, we need to map and understand its complexity:

- Equity-minded holistic approach
- Cross cutting (over range of admissions processes)



Focus on assessment criteria

- At the heart of the doctoral admission process
 - All departments use sets of criteria (quantified or qualitative) to assess applications
 - Place different levels of importance on:
 - the 'person' (e.g. in STEM and medical sciences) or
 - the 'project' (e.g. in social sciences and humanities).
- Biases can emerge where selection criteria are unclear
 - May allow decisions motivated by a range of different values or agendas linked with assessors' own career goals or academic aims
- Rigid criteria, rigidly applied, may reject marginalized candidates
 - May result in inequitable processes of PGR admission, disadvantaging applicants from a range of backgrounds

Guidelines

- Engage staff in discussions to promote better understanding of criteria and how they shape admission decisions
 - Understanding of academic potential and merit vary across disciplines, departments and individual assessor (contested)
- Frame discussions within wider University EDI policies and Public Sector Equality Duty
- Annual review - refining criteria is an on-going process

	Getting started
1.	What is the <u>nature</u> of a doctorate in this department? <i>e.g., in terms of structure, research practices, etc.</i>
2.	What is the <u>purpose</u> of a doctorate in this department/discipline?
3.	How is 'potential' to successfully complete a doctorate conceptualised in this discipline? <i>i.e., what is it we value in prospective DPhil applicants?</i>
4.	How can we expand our definition of 'potential' to include forms of excellence, quality, and merit beyond what is reflected in the current criteria?
5.	What skills, competencies, knowledge, attributes and qualifications reflect 'potential'? <i>e.g. resilience, passion, independence</i>
6.	How can the skills, competencies, knowledge, etc., be assessed?
7.	What evidence will you use for meeting assessment criteria?
8.	Are the criteria flexible enough to allow for the application of contextual data?
9.	Do the criteria reflect the Public Sector Equality Duty / University EDI policies?
10.	Do the criteria reflect core values of the universities access strategy and broad principles of fairness and justice?
11.	Do you need different criteria for shortlisting and interviewing?

	Applying criteria
1.	To what extent can the criteria be applied objectively?
2.	What training do assessors need to understand the purpose and meaning of the criteria, and how to apply them?

	Communicating criteria to students
1.	How are the assessment criteria communicated to applicants? Are they communicated transparently? Do applicants know how they are to be assessed? e.g., detailed list of criteria on university website



UNIVERSITY OF
CAMBRIDGE



UNIVERSITY OF
OXFORD

CLOSE
THE GAP

Fair Admissions in Postgraduate Research



Equity in Doctoral Education through Partnership and Innovation

Lauren Russell

Nottingham Trent University



The EDEPI Programme

- RE and OfS funded, one of 13 projects created to tackle inequalities that create barriers to access and participation in postgraduate research
- Collaboration between Nottingham Trent University, Sheffield Hallam University and Liverpool John Moores University
- Delivery partners: UKCGE, AdvanceHE, GRIT Breakthrough Programmes, NHS
- Launched February 2022
- Initiatives target recruitment, admissions and transition

Work-based partnership approach to postgraduate researcher recruitment

Aims to challenge closed recruitment practices that create barriers to access

Partnership with NHS trusts across Nottingham, Sheffield and Liverpool

Need for improved understanding and practice in areas that impact racially minoritised groups

Pre-doctoral outreach programme to provide information and support

Fee waivers and ring-fenced CPD time

Model that can be replicated across HEIs – doesn't need to have a healthcare focus

Pre-doctoral outreach programme

Series of workshops to provide information to potential candidates on what a PhD entails, and how to effectively prepare for application

- Workshop 1: PhD Myth Busting – Is it right for me?
- Workshop 2: Building your team and research idea
- Workshop 3: Preparing for application

Drop-in sessions are provided for the applicants between workshops 2 and 3 to provide additional support in identifying supervisory teams

****Session on pre-doctoral outreach programme available at 15:25**





Reforming admissions practice

Graduate Admissions Process Survey Report

The survey aimed to:

- target staff involved in PGR admissions to understand better the practices that may have led to the existing admissions gap;
- find examples of practice that support and enable inclusion at doctoral level; and
- highlight priority areas for improvement.

Overview

- 253 / 46 universities represented
- Ten barriers to PGR admissions identified
- Practical recommendations split into four key themes (pre-application, data gaps, supervisors as gatekeepers & fair process)

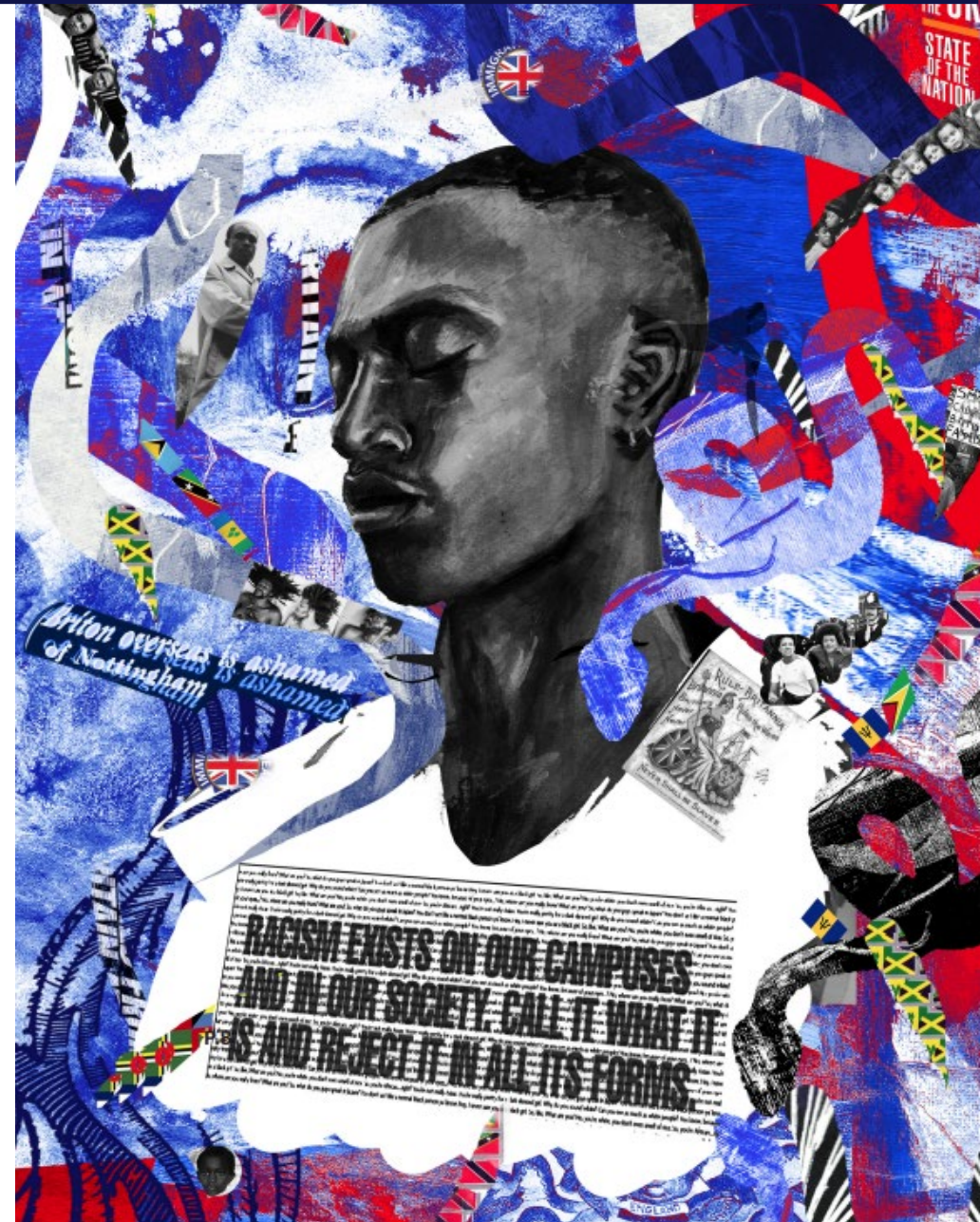
Barriers

- Admissions decisions weighted heavily on pre-application period which is unstructured.
- Lack of diversity in supervisory community.
- Reliance on master's degree and previous awarding institution.
- Data is not usually collected on doctoral enquiries and unsuccessful applications, making leaks in the pipeline hard to identify.
- Support for finding a supervisor and developing a research proposal is less available than information on standard admissions processes but more valuable to applicants from under-represented groups.
- Decision-making is weighted significantly in favour of the supervisor.



Recommendations

- Consider how the pre-application period can be made more structured, open, and transparent.
- Review existing pre-application support for fit with applicant needs and known inequalities related to social and cultural capital.
- Explore what training and information you and/or other supervisors in your university need, to enable them to engage fully with doctoral enquirers and applicants
- Review assessment criteria, where used, and their relative weighting, bearing in mind that systemic inequalities at undergraduate and postgraduate taught levels have created attainment and access gaps for some applicants from racially minoritised groups.
- Explore whether your university PGR admissions data are accessible to all staff involved in PGR recruitment and admissions and at the right level of granularity for their role.





EDEPI Competencies Framework

UK Council for
Graduate Education

Comprehension & Evaluation

Collect, order, evaluate and review results objectively, and communicate with clarity

Analytical & Problem Solving

- Identify connections and patterns in information/data, text or artefact
- Identify and respond to gaps, errors and irregularities in information
- Review results and derive meaning from data, text or artefact
- Create new value relating to the potential contribution of the research in different spheres

Communication

- Communicate ideas and information in writing with clarity and precision
- Present information and ideas verbally, using active listening, focus, and empathy to understand the audience and adapt to meet their needs
- Write reports and papers that are accurate and evidenced
- Consider impact of research and how it might reach widest audiences

Planning and Organisation

- Grasp and order information coming from multiple sources
- Set, maintain and ensure a clear direction for a project or activity
- Anticipate, think ahead and identify the next steps in a project or activity
- Responsive to new issues and ideas as they emerge
- Able to make on-going improvements

Delivering Results

Generate and deliver outcomes on time and to standard

Integrity

- Treat data or information with due care, in compliance with ethical requirements
- Monitor and store data securely and accurately, confidentially and responsibly
- Show respect and understanding of diverse points of view
- Be alert to biases in systems and processes and conflicts of interest
- Examine own biases and behaviours to avoid stereotypical responses and do not discriminate against any individual or group
- Maintain the highest standards of integrity in their work at all times
- Understand the expected standards of rigour and integrity relevant to research

Working with Others

- Seek guidance when required and engages with direction in an open-minded way
- Actively listen to others, share information, and propose suggestions and solutions
- Keep supervisors and collaborators informed of progress
- Respond appropriately to feedback and take action to improve
- Take an interest / engages with the work of others and contributes time and effort to support them
- Look for connections between own work and others and seeks collaboration where appropriate
- Make a positive contribution to the area through activities such as peer-mentoring, volunteering, working with community organisations

Independence

- Recognise opportunities to enhance performance
- Find ways to go around obstacles with minimum guidance
- Take appropriate steps at the appropriate moment and within the given deadlines
- Able to make meaning and to grow from own experiences
- Use reflection as an active strategy to support learning and continuously improve performance
- Independently identify and engage in tasks required for the project
- Take initiative to suggest ideas for improvements, sharing ideas in a constructive manner
- Identify the technical, personal or professional skills required for a task and take action to develop those skills appropriately

Socio-Emotional Competancies

Assume responsibility for performance and seek help when necessary

Motivation

- Actively engage with policy, practice, publications in proposed area of research to keep up to date
- Identify what drives them and demonstrate staying power
- Willingness to add their voice to an ongoing conversation in a discipline or area of knowledge
- Willingness to immerse oneself in the chosen field

Curiosity

- Wants to ask 'why'
- Wants to know more
- Comfortable with uncertainty
- Wants to think deeply about complex ideas and engage with tools to shed new light on data, text or artefact
- Value the knowledge of others

Resilience

- Recognise opportunities for improvement and propose change with impact and effect
- Willingness to effectively reorganise activities when faced with changing contexts and demands
- Adjust approaches and responses to reflect changing circumstances or thinking
- Remain constructive in dealing with setbacks
- Courage to sit with complex ideas that they haven't come across before and to cross cognitive thresholds

Creating a more inclusive research culture

- Bespoke workshops co-created with GRIT Breakthrough Programmes and AdvanceHE
- Staff workshops to enable organisational and behavioural change
- PGR workshops focus on shifting limiting beliefs, addressing isolation and providing safe spaces – holistic development
- Funding competitions open to PGR and staff to trial small-scale interventions across academic schools



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EDEPI@ntu.ac.uk



**[https://www.linkedin.com/
in/edepi/](https://www.linkedin.com/in/edepi/)**



UKCGE Workshop: New perspectives to improve fairness and equity in PGR assessment criteria



Pro:NE

Dr Benjamin Ajibade

Interim Institutional Lead

Northumbria University

Pro Vikki Boliver

Admission Lead

Removing barriers in postgraduate research for
people of colour and racially minoritised researchers

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Pro:NE

UKCGE Workshop: New perspectives to improve fairness and equity in PGR assessment criteria

Focus on	Focus on 'home' students
Bid	Bid developed by: Professor Jason Arday
Project	Project sponsor: PVC EDI Dr Shaid Mahmood
Project	Project manager: Gareth Lawson

Introductions

Admissions: To make admissions more equitable, review policies, pilot new processes, to increase access for students of colour

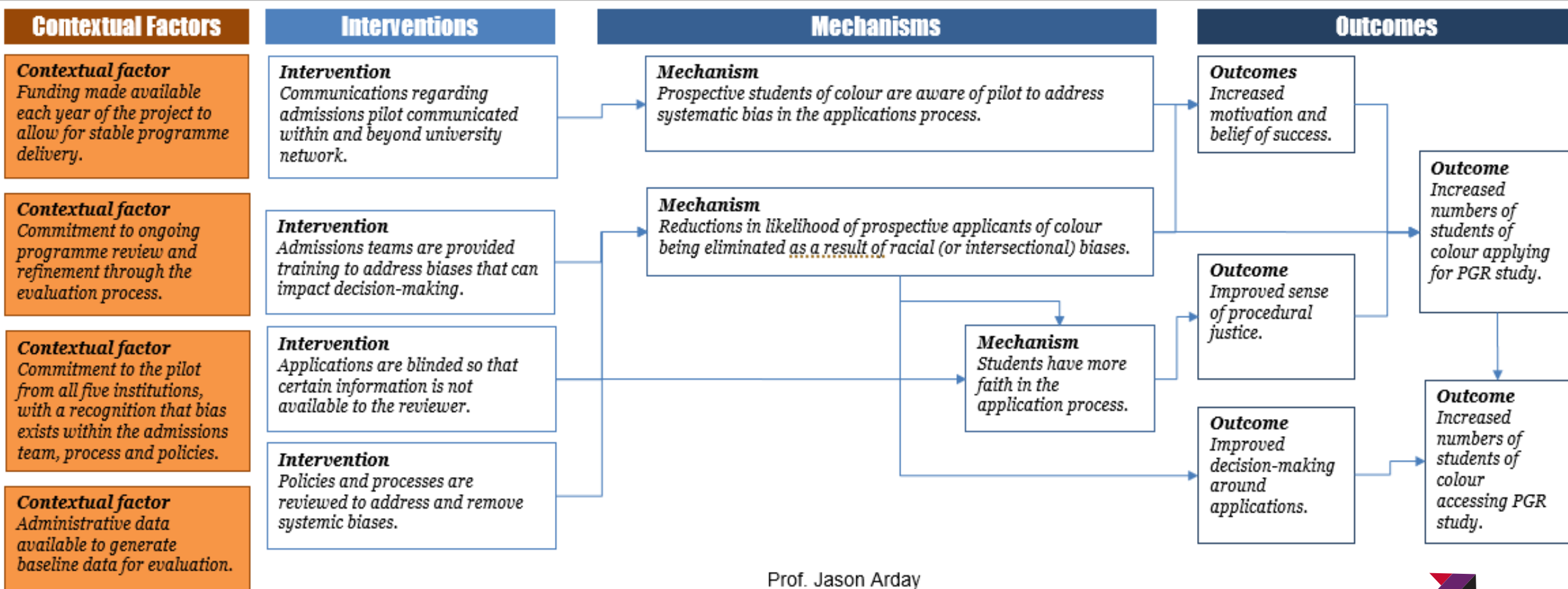


Key questions:

- How **ethnically diverse** are the home (UK-domiciled) PGR populations in the universities of the North East?
 - Are there differential rates of **application** to PGR programmes; if so, how can barriers to application be removed?
 - Are there differential rates of **admission** given application; if so, how can admission rates be made equitable?
- 

Pro:NE Logic Model - Admission

Problem statement: Access to and participation in postgraduate research (PGR) for Black, Asian and Minority Ethnic students is limited by persistent inequalities that exist throughout higher education.
Strand-specific problem statement: Barriers within the admissions process perpetuate inequalities that limit access and participation for Black, Asian and Minority Ethnic students in PGR.



Prof. Jason Arday
Durham University

Data from Focus group - Admission

All participants have not engaged in professional help to apply

Online reading / university website / information on scholarship / Google



Friend / Peers / Supervisor

Information about admission criteria / marks

Transparency on funding availability

Detailed timeline / application status – for better planning



How to improve your profile / CV for better chance of admission



Data from Focus group exercise

Barrier to Admission

What do you think are the key barriers for UK-based students of colour to gain access to PGR studies?

- Lack of student motivation/confidence / family
- Funding issue
- Lack of job opportunities, career advancement
- Mature student (left university life and rejoin after some time)
- Perception on preference (white vs minority ethnic, male vs female)
- Discrimination of admission process (should be equally distributed, merit-based)
- Insufficient advice / support for admission to PGR
- Lack of role models
- Socio-economic pressure (need to provide for family sooner)

What was your experience of the application process like?

- The process was gruelling and stressful.
- All participants have not engaged in professional help to apply other than reference to online reading / university website / information on scholarship / Google, Friend / Peers / Supervisor
- How to write a good proposal / personal statement, secure a supervisor and more clarity about the overall application process and requirement for ATAS certificate

PhD does not reflect better remuneration / performance monitoring

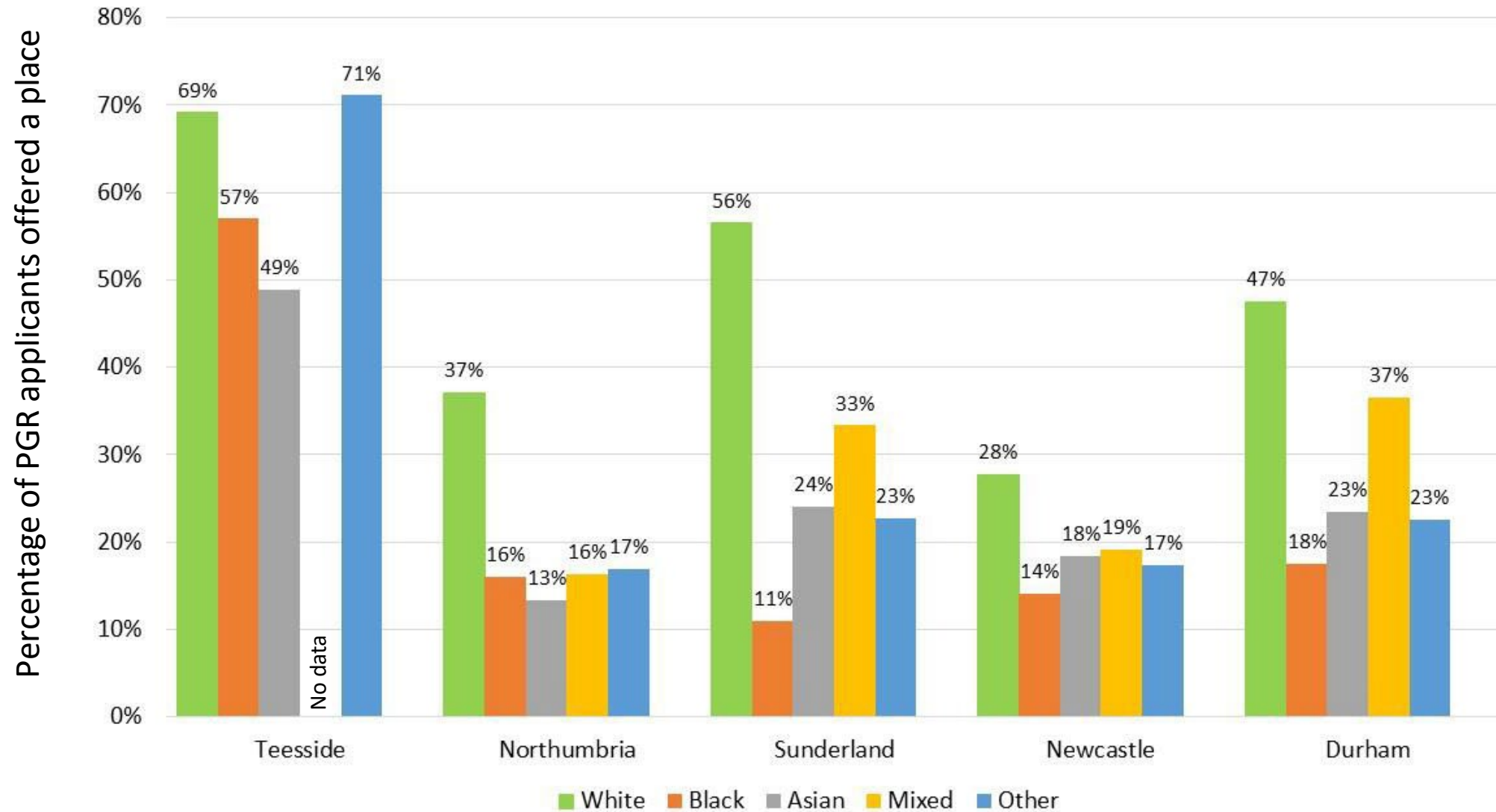
Despite (a), applicants need to be ready for competition, being up to the standard and face rejection

- Lack of student motivation / confidence / culture barrier
- Lack of support from employer (study leave, financial incentive)
- PhD perceived as personal rather than professional achievement



Pro:NE

Racially minoritised PGR applicants less likely to be offered a place



INITIATIVES

Explore whether lower acceptance rates to PGR programmes at the five universities of the North East for British non-White ethnic minority applicants as compared to White British applicants are **associated with systematic differences in the application materials submitted by these two groups.**

Institutional investment in high-quality advertising of PGR opportunities, benefits, and how to apply, targeted at racially minoritised people

Development of high-quality digital materials to improve the visibility of current PGR students and current academic staff from racially minoritised groups on the university website, in digital marketing materials, and on social media

Development of a set of materials for use by prospective supervisors to provide structured support to prospective PGRs and co-develop a PGR application

Recruitment of current home PGRs from racially minoritised groups to provide additional advice and support to prospective PGRs preparing PGR applications

IDENTIFYING AND REMOVING BARRIERS

- Make PGR admissions criteria and processes more racially equitable. Applicants from racially minoritised backgrounds are likely to be affected by the following



Less likely to hold a first or upper second class degree



Less likely to have graduated from a higher-tariff university



Less likely to receive a funded PhD scholarship



May want/need to have someone on the supervisory team who is also from a racially minoritised background



Racial bias (conscious or unconscious) on the part of prospective supervisors, admissions selectors, and PhD scholarship funding panel members

- Ineligible for PGR study
Considered a weaker candidate for PGR study
- Limited or no access to insider information about PGR opportunities and application requirements/processes
- May find it difficult to identify a suitable supervisor from a racially minoritised background
- Prospective supervisors may be less likely to respond positively to PGR enquiries from racially minoritised applicants
- PGR admissions/funding selectors may make biased decisions

RESEARCH DESIGN FOR AN ANALYSIS OF SAMPLE PGR APPLICATION

Sample 48 applications,
giving an overall sample size
of 240 applications

Applications will be sampled
from the most recent year(s) for
which admissions decisions have
already been recorded (starting
with 2021/22, then previous
years as needed to meet the
sampling criteria).

For each institution, the sample
will include 3 applications that
meet each of the following
criteria with respect to applicant
ethnicity, sex, broad academic
discipline, and whether or not an
offer was made.

For each sampled applicant, we will
retrieve the following application
materials for analysis: Applicant's
completed institution-specific
application form, Applicant's curriculum
vitae, Applicant's research proposal (or
equivalent), Applicant's personal
statement (or equivalent) and
Applicant's references.

Application materials for
each institution will be coded
using a pre-agreed set of
deductive codes, same data
will be analysed

Previous education,
qualifications and experience
and evidence of relevant
professional experience



Pro:NE

Removing barriers in postgraduate research for
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Assessing the potential of applicants from diverse backgrounds

Review the profiles shared.

What attributes do you think the applicant could have that would demonstrate their research potential for the course they have applied for?

(e.g. communication skills, resilience, planning).

How could these attributes be equitably assessed throughout the applicant review process? *(e.g. equal weighting for academic experience and professional experience...)*



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Thank you - keep in touch..

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[Home - Yorkshire Consortium for Equity in Doctoral Education \(ycede.ac.uk\)](http://ycede.ac.uk)

